



volved what the Indian had wrought.

The single biggest surprise in Anand's game was switching his opening from his patented king pawn which he has used for almost his entire career to a queen pawn opening. In tennis, this would be like a right-hander walking into a Wimbledon final and serving left-handed. Other than proving to be a shock to the opponent's system, it would force a re-alignment of the entire game plan. More so in chess where the plan and the execution feed off each other.

Other than the two contenders involved, every world chess final features another important set of combatants:

ELEGANT MOVE: The champion and a dejected Kramnik (left)

the backroom teams. Kramnik's team also featured among others, Peter Leko of Hungary, Anand's long-time friend and former 'second'.

The Indian's backroom team was announced but remained cloistered in his hotel for the entire competition. They included former world champion Rustam Kasimdzhanov of Uzbekistan, Peter Heine Nielsen of Denmark, his 'second' for the last four years, Indian National champion Surya Shekhar Ganguly and a surprise package in the

22-year-old Pole, Radoslaw Wojtaszek. Impressed by Wojtaszek's thinking during their meetings in the German league, Anand decided to add him to his team of 'seconds' along with Hans-Walter Schmitt, the German who organises the Chess Classic of Mainz.

Before coming to Bonn, both men sought the help of some younger up-coming chess prodigies on the quiet, Anand with 17-year-old Norwegian Magnus Carlsen and Kramnik with Ukrainian teenager Sergey Karjakin.

But in terms of ideas it was evident that Anand had Kramnik's scalp. His excellent home preparation and the novel moves he uncorked every day in the first half had a psychological affect on and off the board. The Russian was able to win only a single game out of 11; Anand won three, two with black.

Kramnik's capitulation came as a shock to Russia with Moscow-based women's grandmaster Elmira Mirzoeva saying the atmosphere at home would be "like at a funeral. The world chess title is treated like a national treasure in Russia."

After Bonn, Anand has forcibly silenced the rude murmurs of dissent that have denied a great champion the respect he was owed. His cupboard is now full—along with three world titles and two world Cups, Anand has won titles in the compressed forms of the game. He has one world Blitz title, he has won 11 Rapid titles in the format's biggest event held in Mainz. The closest analogy is that if Blitz (every player is given 25 minutes to complete a game) is like 50-overs cricket, rapid is the T-20 version of chess where every player has only five minutes to complete a game. Along with the superfast formats, Anand has logged in victories at the most elite level of chess winning Linares and Dortmund thrice and the Corsica event five times.

As different formats flourished and an increasingly political world played favourites, Bonn turned into Anand's final frontier. He crossed with imperiousness, and his triumph will carry a long and a loud echo. He stripped the event of its non-essentials and stuck to what he knew best: the art and science of chess.

The author is a chess writer and a former international player